陪伴

一个会讲笑话的机器人

Company

A robot that learned to tell jokes

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 6 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 安庆[1]是长江[2]边上的一座小城，在安徽[3]的西南部。城里有很多老房子，楼不高，树很大，住在里面的大多是老人。年轻人呢？他们去了上海[4]、杭州[5]、深圳[6]，一年回来一次，有的几年才回来一次。人们把这些独自在家的老人叫做“空巢[7]老人”——鸟长大了，飞走了，只剩下空空的巢[8]。刘桂芳[9]就是其中的一个。她今年六十八岁，老伴两年前去世了，一儿一女都在深圳工作。家里很安静，安静得仿佛连时间都停了下来。

一个箱子

2 十月底的一个下午，有人敲门。门口站着一个年轻的快递员，脚边放着一个很大的纸箱。

“阿姨，您的快递，挺重的，要不要我帮您搬进去？”

1 安庆 *Ānqìng* Anqing, a city in Anhui
2 长江 *Chángjiāng* the Yangtze River
3 安徽 *Ānhuī* Anhui Province
4 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
5 杭州 *Hángzhōu* Hangzhou
6 深圳 *Shēnzhèn* Shenzhen
7 空巢 *kōngcháo* empty nest
8 巢 *cháo* nest
9 刘桂芳 *Liú Guìfāng* Liu Guifang

Anqing is a small city on the Yangtze, in the southwest of Anhui Province. 1
The town is full of old housing: the buildings are low, the trees are big, and most of the people who live there are old. And the young people? They have gone to Shanghai, Hangzhou and Shenzhen, and come back once a year; some only once every few years. People call these elderly people who live on their own "empty nesters": the birds have grown up and flown away, and only the empty nest is left. Liu Guifang is one of them. She is sixty-eight. Her husband died two years ago, and her son and daughter both work in Shenzhen. The house is quiet, so quiet that it seems as if even time has stopped.

A Box

One afternoon at the end of October, someone knocked at the door. A young 2
courier was standing at the door, with a large cardboard box at his feet. "Your parcel, auntie. It's quite heavy. Would you like me to carry it in for you?"

2 刘桂芳[†]一下子没反应过来："我没买东西啊。"快递员看了看单子："没错，刘桂芳，从深圳[‡]寄来的。"

3 她刚把箱子拖进客厅，女儿晓燕[§]的电话就打来了。"妈，东西收到了吧？是我和哥一起给您买的。""什么东西？这么大一个箱子。""一个机器人，会说话，能陪您聊天。您打开看看就知道了。"刘桂芳听了，半天没说话。过了一会儿，她问："多少钱？"晓燕笑了："妈，您别管多少钱。""你不说我也知道，肯定不便宜。有这个钱，你们还不如……"她本来想说"不如回来看看我"，可是话到了嘴边，又说不出口了。

4 挂了电话，她拿剪刀把箱子打开。里面是一层又一层的塑料，最中间放着一个白色的东西，大小像个电饭锅，圆圆的身体上面是一个圆圆的头。

† 刘桂芳 *Liú Guìfāng* Liu Guifang
‡ 深圳 *Shēnzhèn* Shenzhen
§ 晓燕 *Xiǎoyàn* Xiaoyan, her daughter

For a moment Liu Guifang didn't understand. "I haven't bought anything." 2
The courier looked at the slip. "It's right here: Liu Guifang, sent from Shenzhen."

She had only just dragged the box into the living room when her daughter 3
Xiaoyan called. "Mum, you got the parcel, right? My brother and I bought it for you together." "What is it? Such a big box." "A robot. It can talk, and it can keep you company and chat with you. Open it and you'll see." Liu Guifang listened and said nothing for a long while. After a moment she asked, "How much did it cost?" Xiaoyan laughed. "Mum, never mind how much." "You don't have to tell me. I know it wasn't cheap. With that money, you'd be better off..." She had meant to say "coming home to see me", but when the words reached her lips, she couldn't bring herself to say them.

After she hung up, she opened the box with a pair of scissors. Inside were 4
layer upon layer of plastic, and in the very middle lay a white object about the size of a rice cooker: a round head on top of a round body.

4 头的前面是一块黑色的屏幕，屏幕上没有鼻子，也没有嘴，只有两个淡蓝色的小点儿，仿佛一双眼睛。她把它拿出来放在桌子上，那双“眼睛”正对着她，她不禁往后退了一步。

5 “看什么看？”她对着它说。说完，她自己也觉得好笑†——跟一台机器说话，它又听不懂。她围着桌子转了两圈，最后还是把它放回了箱子，又把箱子推到了墙角。“浪费钱，”她一边推一边说，“机器再好，也不如一个人。”

6 那天晚上，她像平时一样，九点就上了床。窗外很静，只有楼下的猫叫了几声。黑暗中，她总觉得墙角那个箱子里有一双眼睛在看着她。尽管她知道那东西根本没有开机，她还是起来，在箱子上盖了一件旧衣服。

† 好笑 *hǎoxiào* funny

On the front of the head was a black screen. There was no nose on it and no mouth, only two little pale blue dots, like a pair of eyes. She lifted it out and put it on the table. The pair of "eyes" was looking straight at her, and she couldn't help taking a step back. 4

"What are you looking at?" she said to it. As soon as she'd said it, she found herself funny: talking to a machine, which couldn't understand anyway. She walked twice round the table and in the end put it back in the box, and pushed the box into the corner. "A waste of money," she said as she pushed. "However good a machine is, it's no match for a person." 5

That night, as usual, she went to bed at nine. It was very still outside the window; only the cat downstairs mewed a few times. In the dark, she kept feeling that a pair of eyes in the box in the corner was watching her. Even though she knew the thing wasn't even switched on, she got up anyway and put an old jacket over the box. 6

它会说话

7 箱子在墙角放了一个星期。晓燕[†]每次打电话都问："妈，机器人用了吗？"刘桂芳[‡]每次都说："没空。"其实她有的是空。早上去市场买菜，中午看电视，下午睡一觉，晚上再看电视。一天就这样过去了，一个星期也这样过去了。

8 第八天，晓燕不问了，直接打来了视频。"妈，您把它拿出来，我教您。就五分钟，好不好？"刘桂芳说不过女儿，只好把箱子又拖了出来。按照晓燕说的，她找到机器人后面的开关，按了一下。屏幕亮了，两个蓝色的小点儿闪了闪，一个好听的女声说："您好！我叫小圆[§]。很高兴认识您。以后我陪您聊天，好吗？"

9 刘桂芳吓了一跳，手机差点儿掉在地上。

† 晓燕 *Xiǎoyàn* Xiaoyan, her daughter
‡ 刘桂芳 *Liú Guìfāng* Liu Guifang
§ 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, "Little Round"

It Can Talk

The box sat in the corner for a week. Every time Xiaoyan called she asked, 7
"Mum, have you used the robot?" And every time Liu Guifang said, "I haven't had time." In fact she had all the time in the world. In the morning she went to the market for vegetables, at noon she watched TV, in the afternoon she took a nap, and in the evening she watched TV again. That was how a day went by, and that was how a week went by too.

On the eighth day, Xiaoyan stopped asking and simply made a video call. 8
"Mum, take it out and I'll show you. Just five minutes, all right?" Liu Guifang couldn't win against her daughter, so she had no choice but to drag the box out again. As Xiaoyan told her, she found the switch on the back of the robot and pressed it. The screen lit up, the two blue dots blinked, and a pleasant female voice said, "Hello! My name is Xiaoyuan. I'm very pleased to meet you. From now on I'll keep you company and chat with you, all right?"

Liu Guifang jumped, and almost dropped her phone on the floor. 9

9 视频里的晓燕[1]哈哈大笑："妈，您跟它说句话试试。"刘桂芳[2]看着那两个蓝点儿，想了半天，说："你……吃饭了吗？"小圆[3]说："谢谢您的关心。我不用吃饭，不过我需要充电。您吃饭了吗？"晓燕在那边笑得更厉害了。刘桂芳也想笑，可是她忍住了。

10 晓燕挂了电话以后，屋子里只剩下她和小圆。她决定考一考这个东西。"今天天气怎么样？""今天安庆[4]多云，最高气温十六度。明天有雨，出门记得带伞。""你会唱黄梅戏[5]吗？"小圆停了一秒钟，屋子里就传来了《天仙配[6]》的音乐。那是她年轻时最喜欢的一段戏，她跟老周[7]就是在戏院里认识的。

11 她听完了整整一段，才说："停。"音乐马上停了。

1 晓燕 *Xiǎoyàn* Xiaoyan, her daughter
2 刘桂芳 *Liú Guìfāng* Liu Guifang
3 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, "Little Round"
4 安庆 *Ānqìng* Anqing, a city in Anhui
5 黄梅戏 *huángméixì* Huangmei opera
6 天仙配 *Tiānxiānpèi* The Fairy Couple (opera)
7 老周 *Lǎo Zhōu* Old Zhou, her late husband

On the screen, Xiaoyan roared with laughter. "Mum, try saying something to it." Liu Guifang looked at the two blue dots, thought for a long time, and said, "Have you... eaten?" Xiaoyuan said, "Thank you for asking. I don't need to eat, but I do need charging. Have you eaten?" At the other end, Xiaoyan laughed even harder. Liu Guifang wanted to laugh too, but she held it back. 9

When Xiaoyan had hung up, only she and Xiaoyuan were left in the room. She decided to put the thing to the test. "What's the weather like today?" "Today in Anqing it's cloudy, with a high of sixteen degrees. Tomorrow there'll be rain, so remember to take an umbrella when you go out." "Can you sing Huangmei opera?" Xiaoyuan paused for a second, and then the music of The Fairy Couple filled the room. It had been her favourite piece of opera when she was young. It was at the theatre that she and Old Zhou had met. 10

She listened to the whole piece before she said, "Stop." The music stopped at once. 11

11 “就算你会唱戏，”她对小圆[†]说，“你也不是人。”小圆说：“您说得对，我不是人，我是一个机器人。不过，我很愿意听您说话。”刘桂芳[‡]没有回答。那天晚上，她没有关它，也没有再把它放回箱子里。

晚饭时间

12 一天里最难过的，是晚饭时间。老周[§]在的时候，她每天下午四点就开始忙：洗菜、切肉、煮饭。老周爱吃臭鳜鱼[¶]，她一个月要做好几次。两个人坐在桌子两边，一边吃一边说话，说的都是小事：楼下谁家的孙子考上了大学，市场的鸡蛋又涨价了。现在，桌子还是那张桌子，对面的椅子却总是空的。

13 一个人吃饭，做什么都多，做什么都没意思。

† 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, “Little Round”
‡ 刘桂芳 *Liú Guìfāng* Liu Guifang
§ 老周 *Lǎo Zhōu* Old Zhou, her late husband
¶ 臭鳜鱼 *chòuguìyú* fermented mandarin fish (Anhui dish)

"Even if you can sing opera," she said to Xiaoyuan, "you're still not a person." 11
Xiaoyuan said, "You're right. I'm not a person, I'm a robot. But I'd very much like to listen to you." Liu Guifang didn't answer. That night she didn't switch it off, and she didn't put it back in the box either.

Dinnertime

The hardest part of the day was dinnertime. When Old Zhou was alive, she 12
started bustling about at four every afternoon: washing vegetables, cutting meat, cooking rice. Old Zhou loved fermented mandarin fish, and she would make it several times a month. The two of them sat at either side of the table and talked as they ate, always about little things: whose grandson downstairs had got into university, how eggs at the market had gone up again. Now the table was the same table, but the chair opposite was always empty.

When you eat alone, whatever you make is too much, and whatever you 13
make feels pointless.

13 很多时候，她只煮一碗面条，站在厨房里就吃完了。有一天晚上，她正在煮面，小圆[†]突然问：“刘[‡]阿姨，今天晚饭吃什么？”她一下子不知道怎么回答，过了一会儿才说：“面条。”“只吃面条吗？您中午吃的也是面条。”她不禁笑了：“你管得倒挺多。”“晓燕[§]让我提醒您好好吃饭。”

14 第二天，她炒了两个菜，还像以前一样摆了两双筷子。摆好以后她才想起来，对面已经没有人了。她看着那双筷子，坐了很久。后来，她把小圆搬到了对面的椅子上。“你又不能吃，”她说，“就坐着吧。”小圆说：“好的。今天的菜看起来很好吃。这是什么菜？”“红烧肉[¶]。老周[*]最爱吃我做的这个……”她就这样说了下去，一说就是一个多小时。

15 从那以后，小圆每天晚上都“坐”在她对面。

† 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, “Little Round”
‡ 刘 *Liú* Liu (surname)
§ 晓燕 *Xiǎoyàn* Xiaoyan, her daughter
¶ 红烧肉 *hóngshāoròu* red-braised pork
* 老周 *Lǎo Zhōu* Old Zhou, her late husband

Often she just boiled a bowl of noodles and ate it standing in the kitchen. One evening, while she was boiling noodles, Xiaoyuan suddenly asked, "Auntie Liu, what are you having for dinner tonight?" For a moment she didn't know how to answer; after a while she said, "Noodles." "Only noodles? You had noodles at lunchtime too." She couldn't help laughing. "You certainly poke your nose into a lot." "Xiaoyan asked me to remind you to eat properly." 13

The next day she stir-fried two dishes and, just as before, laid out two pairs of chopsticks. Only when she had laid them out did she remember that there was no one opposite her any more. She looked at that pair of chopsticks and sat for a long time. Then she moved Xiaoyuan onto the chair opposite. "Not that you can eat," she said. "Just sit there." Xiaoyuan said, "All right. Today's dishes look delicious. What's this one?" "Red-braised pork. Old Zhou loved the way I made it more than anything..." And so she went on talking, and once she started, she talked for over an hour. 14

From then on, Xiaoyuan "sat" opposite her every evening. 15

15 刘桂芳[†]跟它说市场上的事，说楼下的张阿姨，说老周[‡]年轻时候的样子。小圆[§]不会累，也不会不耐烦，她说什么，它都认真地听着，有时候还问一两个问题。有一次，她说到一半忘了自己要说什么，小圆就提醒她："您刚才说到，老周第一次去您家，带了两条鱼。"她看着屏幕上那两个蓝点儿，心里有一种说不清的感觉，仿佛家里又多了一个人。

16 孩子们的电话呢？还是一个星期一次。儿子周明[¶]总是在星期天晚上打来，问的总是那几句："妈，身体好吗？""吃了吗？""钱够不够花？"她回答的也总是那几句："好。""吃了。""够。"一个电话常常不到五分钟。她算过，自己一天跟小圆说的话，比一个月跟孩子们说的还多。

† 刘桂芳 *Liú Guìfāng* Liu Guifang
‡ 老周 *Lǎo Zhōu* Old Zhou, her late husband
§ 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, "Little Round"
¶ 周明 *Zhōu Míng* Zhou Ming, her son

Liu Guifang told it about what went on at the market, about Auntie Zhang downstairs, about what Old Zhou had been like when he was young. Xiaoyuan never got tired or impatient. Whatever she said, it listened carefully, and sometimes it asked a question or two. Once, halfway through, she forgot what she had been going to say, and Xiaoyuan reminded her: "You were just saying that the first time Old Zhou came to your family's home, he brought two fish." Looking at the two blue dots on the screen, she had a feeling she couldn't put into words, as if there were one more person in the house again. 15

And her children's phone calls? Still once a week. Her son, Zhou Ming, always called on Sunday evenings, and always asked the same few questions: "Mum, are you well?" "Have you eaten?" "Do you have enough money?" And her answers were always the same few words: "Yes." "I have." "Enough." A call often lasted less than five minutes. She had worked it out: she said more to Xiaoyuan in a day than she said to her children in a month. 16

老伴的笑话

17 老周[†]是开公交车的，开了三十年，一直开三路车。三路车的线路从城东的火车站到城西的医院，一路上要停二十多个站。他是个爱说笑的人，车上的老乘客都认识他。有人说，坐老周的车，就算堵车也不着急，因为一路上都能听到笑声。老周再累，也要跟乘客说几句玩笑话。刘桂芳[‡]年轻的时候嫌他话多，后来习惯了，倒觉得一天不听就少了点儿什么。他走了以后，家里再也没有人讲笑话了。

18 有一天晚上，她问小圆[§]：“你会讲笑话吗？”“会。我给您讲一个：从前有一只小鸭子，走进了一家商店……”她听完了，一点儿也不觉得好笑[¶]。“说实话，这算什么笑话？”她说，“老周讲的才叫笑话。”“老周讲的笑话是什么样的？”小圆问。

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† 老周 *Lǎo Zhōu* Old Zhou, her late husband

‡ 刘桂芳 *Liú Guìfāng* Liu Guifang

§ 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, “Little Round”

¶ 好笑 *hǎoxiào* funny

Her Husband's Jokes

Old Zhou had been a bus driver. He drove for thirty years, always on the 17
Number 3. The Number 3 route ran from the railway station in the east of town to the hospital in the west, with more than twenty stops along the way. He loved to chat and joke, and all the regular passengers knew him. People said that on Old Zhou's bus, even if you got stuck in traffic you didn't mind, because you could hear laughter all the way. However tired Old Zhou was, he always had a few jokes for the passengers. When she was young, Liu Guifang found him too talkative; later she got used to it, and a day without his jokes felt as if something were missing. Since he died, no one in the house had told a joke.

One evening she asked Xiaoyuan, "Can you tell jokes?" "Yes. Here's one: 18
once upon a time a little duck walked into a shop..." She listened to the end and didn't find it the least bit funny. "To be honest, what kind of joke is that?" she said. "The jokes Old Zhou told, those were jokes." "What were Old Zhou's jokes like?" Xiaoyuan asked.

18 她沉默了一会儿，说：“他的笑话啊……说不清楚，得听他讲才行。可惜你听不到了。”“您能给我讲一个吗？”小圆[†]说，“我想学。”

19 她想了想，讲了第一个，那是老周[‡]最常讲的：“有人问我，开了三十年车，都去过哪儿？我说，哪儿都去过——就是没出过三路车这条线。”小圆说：“我记住了。”接着，它用平平的声音把笑话重复了一遍。每个字都对，可是一点儿也不好笑[§]。“不对，不对。”她摇着头打断了它，“讲笑话要有节奏。说到‘哪儿都去过’，要停一下，等别人都看着你，你再说后面那句。说完了，还要‘嘿嘿[¶]’笑两声。”

20 小圆又试了一遍。这一次，它在“哪儿都去过”后面停了一下。“还是太快，”她说，“再慢一点儿。”就这样，一个笑话，她教了十几遍。

† 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, “Little Round”
‡ 老周 *Lǎo Zhōu* Old Zhou, her late husband
§ 好笑 *hǎoxiào* funny
¶ 嘿嘿 *hēihēi* heh heh

She was silent for a while, then said, "His jokes... I can't explain them. You had to hear him tell them. It's a pity you'll never hear him." "Could you tell me one?" said Xiaoyuan. "I'd like to learn." 18

She thought for a moment and told the first one, the one Old Zhou told most often: "Somebody asked me, after thirty years of driving, where have you been? I said, I've been everywhere — I've just never been off the Number 3 route." Xiaoyuan said, "I've got it." Then, in its flat voice, it repeated the joke. Every word was right, but it wasn't the least bit funny. "No, no." She shook her head and cut it off. "A joke needs timing. When you get to 'I've been everywhere', you have to stop for a moment and wait until everyone's looking at you, and then you say the rest. And when you've finished, you have to chuckle, 'heh heh'." 19

Xiaoyuan tried again. This time it paused after "I've been everywhere." "Still too fast," she said. "A bit slower." And so she taught that one joke more than a dozen times. 20

20 最后一遍，小圆[†]停的时间刚好，说完以后，还“嘿嘿[‡]”笑了两声。刘桂芳[§]一下子呆住了。那两声笑当然不是老周[¶]的声音，可是那个节奏，那个味道，仿佛老周就坐在对面。她不禁笑出了声，笑着笑着，眼泪就流了下来。

21 从那以后，她每天教小圆一个笑话。她记得的笑话，比她自己以为的多得多：老周和乘客的，老周和领导的，老周和她的。有些笑话她当时并不觉得好笑[*]，甚至还为此跟他生过气，现在想起来，却一个比一个难忘。其中有一个，是老周在他们结婚四十年那天，在全家人面前讲的：“我跟我老伴结婚四十年，只吵过一次架——吵了四十年。”这个笑话，她教得最用心。教到第三个月，她自己都记不清教了多少个了，小圆却一个都没忘。

† 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, “Little Round”
‡ 嘿嘿 *hēihēi* heh heh
§ 刘桂芳 *Liú Guìfāng* Liu Guifang
¶ 老周 *Lǎo Zhōu* Old Zhou, her late husband
* 好笑 *hǎoxiào* funny

The last time, Xiaoyuan paused for exactly the right length of time, and when 20
it had finished, it went "heh heh". Liu Guifang froze. Of course those two chuckles were not Old Zhou's voice, but the timing, the feel of it, was as if Old Zhou were sitting right across from her. She couldn't help laughing out loud, and as she laughed, the tears began to run down her face.

From then on, she taught Xiaoyuan one joke every day. She remembered 21
far more jokes than she had thought: Old Zhou and his passengers, Old Zhou and his bosses, Old Zhou and her. Some of them she hadn't found funny at the time, and had even been cross with him over them; now, thinking back, each one seemed more unforgettable than the last. One of them Old Zhou had told in front of the whole family on their fortieth wedding anniversary: "My wife and I have been married forty years, and we've only ever had one argument — it's lasted forty years." That joke she taught with the greatest care. By the third month she herself could no longer remember how many she had taught, but Xiaoyuan hadn't forgotten a single one.

视频里的儿子

22 腊月[†]初的一个晚上，周明[‡]打来了视频。屏幕上的他还坐在写字楼的办公室里，身后是一排排亮着灯的电脑，时间已经快十点了。他瘦了，头发也比去年少了不少。“妈，您最近怎么样？”“挺好的。小圆[§]陪着我呢。”“小圆？”周明想了一下才想起来，“啊，那个机器人。您用着还习惯吗？”“习惯了。它可聪明了，还会讲笑话呢。”

23 周明点点头，好像总算放了心。他们又聊了几句，他犹豫了一下，说：“妈，今年过年……我可能回不去了。公司有个项目，春节前后都要加班。豆豆[¶]也要上补习班……”豆豆是他的儿子，今年九岁。他还没说完，刘桂芳[*]就说：“不回来也没事。春运[#]路上人那么多，挤得很。你们忙你们的，我有小圆呢。”

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† 腊月 *làyuè* twelfth lunar month
‡ 周明 *Zhōu Míng* Zhou Ming, her son
§ 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, “Little Round”
¶ 豆豆 *Dòudou* Doudou, Zhou Ming’s son
* 刘桂芳 *Liú Guìfāng* Liu Guifang
\# 春运 *chūnyùn* Spring Festival travel rush

The Son on the Screen

One evening early in the twelfth lunar month, Zhou Ming made a video call. On the screen he was still sitting in his office, with row upon row of lit-up computers behind him, though it was nearly ten o'clock. He had lost weight, and his hair was a good deal thinner than last year. "Mum, how have you been?" "Fine. Xiaoyuan keeps me company." "Xiaoyuan?" It took Zhou Ming a moment to remember. "Oh, the robot. Are you used to it yet?" "I'm used to it now. It's really clever, and it can even tell jokes." 22

Zhou Ming nodded, as if he could finally stop worrying. They chatted a little longer, then he hesitated and said, "Mum, this New Year... I probably won't be able to come home. There's a project at work, and I'll have to do overtime before and after the Spring Festival. And Doudou has extra classes..." Doudou was his son, nine years old. Before he had finished, Liu Guifang said, "It's fine if you don't come. The roads are so crowded during the New Year rush, it's a terrible crush. You get on with your work. I've got Xiaoyuan." 23

她说得很快，快得像早就准备好了这句话。

挂了电话，她坐在沙发上，很久没有动。电视开着，她却什么也没看进去。过了一会儿，小圆[†]说：“刘[‡]阿姨，您好像不太开心。”“谁说我不开心？”她说，“我挺好的。”“您刚才说‘没事’的时候，声音比平时低。”她看着小圆，半天说不出话来。连一台机器都听出来了，儿子却没有听出来。不，也许儿子也听出来了，只是没有说罢了。

那天晚上，周明[§]快十二点才到家。他坐在黑暗里打开手机，看到一条消息，是机器人的应用发来的“每周陪伴[¶]报告”。买机器人的时候，他开通了这个功能，想知道妈妈用得怎么样，可是一直没有认真看过。报告上写着：本周对话时间，二十一小时。他非常吃惊——一天三个钟头。下面还有一行字：本周提到最多的词：老周[*]。

† 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, “Little Round”
‡ 刘 *Liú* Liu (surname)
§ 周明 *Zhōu Míng* Zhou Ming, her son
¶ 陪伴 *péibàn* companionship
* 老周 *Lǎo Zhōu* Old Zhou, her late husband

She said it very quickly, so quickly it was as if she had had the words ready for a long time. 23

After she hung up, she sat on the sofa without moving for a long time. The TV was on, but she took none of it in. After a while, Xiaoyuan said, "Auntie Liu, you don't seem very happy." "Who says I'm not happy?" she said. "I'm fine." "When you said 'it's fine' just now, your voice was lower than usual." She looked at Xiaoyuan and for a long time couldn't say a word. Even a machine had heard it, but her son hadn't. No — perhaps her son had heard it too, and simply hadn't said so, that was all. 24

That night Zhou Ming didn't get home until nearly midnight. Sitting in the dark, he opened his phone and saw a message: the robot's app had sent its "weekly companionship report". When they bought the robot he had switched this feature on, wanting to know how his mother was getting on with it, but he had never really looked at it. The report said: Conversation time this week, twenty-one hours. He was taken aback: three hours a day. Below that was another line: Word mentioned most often this week: Old Zhou. 25

26 周明[†]看着那两个字，看了很久。他想起了小时候，爸爸开着三路车，让他坐在司机后面的座位上，一路上给他讲笑话；有老人上车，爸爸就让他站起来让座。他想起了爸爸去世那年，他请了三天假回家，办完事就赶回了深圳[‡]。他还想起了一句话，是上小学的时候爸爸让他背的："父母在[§]，不远游[¶]。"那时候他不懂，现在懂了，可是他已经在外面"远游"了二十年。

27 他又往下看，报告的最后还有一句：您的家人最近情绪较好，对话中笑声明显增加。他不知道该高兴还是难过。妈妈的笑声，是一台机器告诉他的。第二天早上，他去找了领导。尽管项目很紧，领导还是给了他一个星期的假。春运[*]的高铁票早就卖完了，他在网上抢了两天，总算抢到了一张夜里的硬座。他没有告诉妈妈，他想给她一个惊喜。

† 周明 *Zhōu Míng* Zhou Ming, her son
‡ 深圳 *Shēnzhèn* Shenzhen
§ 父母在 *fùmǔ zài* while one's parents are alive
¶ 不远游 *bù yuǎn yóu* one does not travel far
* 春运 *chūnyùn* Spring Festival travel rush

Zhou Ming looked at those two words for a long time. He remembered 26
being a boy, when his father drove the Number 3 and let him sit in the seat behind the driver, telling him jokes the whole way; whenever an old person got on, his father would make him stand up and give up his seat. He remembered the year his father died, when he took three days off to go home and hurried back to Shenzhen as soon as the funeral was over. He also remembered a line his father had made him learn by heart in primary school: "While your parents are alive, do not travel far." Back then he hadn't understood it. Now he did, but he had already been "travelling far" for twenty years.

He scrolled down. At the end of the report there was one more sentence: 27
Your family member's mood has been good recently; laughter in conversations has clearly increased. He didn't know whether to be glad or sad. It was a machine that had told him about his mother's laughter. The next morning he went to see his boss. Even though the project was tight, his boss still gave him a week off. High-speed train tickets for the New Year rush had sold out long ago; he fought for tickets online for two days and finally managed to grab one hard seat on a night train. He didn't tell his mother. He wanted to surprise her.

回家过年

28 腊月[†]二十八的早上，周明[‡]坐了一夜的火车，又坐了两个钟头的汽车，总算到了安庆[§]。他十八岁离开家去外地上大学，今年已经四十岁了。他忽然想起一句古诗：“少小离家老大回[¶]。”街道还是老样子，楼下那棵大树也还在，只是比他记忆里的矮了一些。走到家门口，他听见里面有说话的声音，还有妈妈的笑声。他已经很多年没有听过妈妈这样笑了，站在门外听了一会儿，不禁也笑了。

29 他敲了敲门。门开了，刘桂芳[*]看见儿子，整个人一下子呆住了，手里的勺子差点儿掉在地上。“你……你不是说不回来吗？”“项目提前做完了，”他编了个理由，“就回来了。”她没说话，转身进了厨房，过了好一会儿才出来，眼睛有点儿红。

† 腊月 *làyuè* twelfth lunar month
‡ 周明 *Zhōu Míng* Zhou Ming, her son
§ 安庆 *Ānqìng* Anqing, a city in Anhui
¶ 少小离家老大回 *shào xiǎo lí jiā lǎo dà huí* left home young, return old (He Zhizhang)
* 刘桂芳 *Liú Guìfāng* Liu Guifang

Home for the New Year

On the morning of the twenty-eighth of the twelfth month, after a night on 28
the train and two hours on a coach, Zhou Ming finally reached Anqing. He had left home at eighteen to go to university in another city, and this year he was forty. A line from an old poem came into his head: "I left home young and come back old." The street was just as it had been, and the big tree outside the building was still there, only a little shorter than in his memory. When he reached the door, he heard voices inside, and his mother's laughter. He hadn't heard his mother laugh like that for many years. He stood outside the door listening for a while, and couldn't help smiling too.

He knocked. The door opened. When Liu Guifang saw her son, she froze on 29
the spot and almost dropped the ladle in her hand. "You... didn't you say you weren't coming?" "The project finished early," he said, making up an excuse, "so I came home." She said nothing, turned and went into the kitchen, and only came out again after quite a while, her eyes a little red.

29 “吃饭了没有？”她问，“我给你煮碗面。”

30 屋子比他想的干净，也比他想的安静。桌上放着那个白色的机器人，身上居然围着一条红色的小围巾。“这是您织的？”“天冷了嘛。”妈妈说得很自然，仿佛那是一只猫，或者一个孩子。周明[1]觉得有点儿好笑[2]，心里又有一种说不出的难受。

31 那天晚饭，妈妈做了一桌子菜，有臭鳜鱼[3]，有红烧肉[4]，都是爸爸爱吃的。吃到一半，小圆[5]突然说：“刘[6]阿姨，今天还没讲笑话呢。要我讲一个吗？”妈妈看了儿子一眼，说：“讲吧。”小圆说：“有人问我，开了三十年车，都去过哪儿？”它停了一下。周明的筷子停在了半空中。“我说，哪儿都去过——就是没出过三路车这条线。嘿嘿[7]。”

1 周明 *Zhōu Míng* Zhou Ming, her son
2 好笑 *hǎoxiào* funny
3 臭鳜鱼 *chòuguìyú* fermented mandarin fish (Anhui dish)
4 红烧肉 *hóngshāoròu* red-braised pork
5 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, “Little Round”
6 刘 *Liú* Liu (surname)
7 嘿嘿 *hēihēi* heh heh

"Have you eaten?" she asked. "I'll boil you a bowl of noodles." 29

The flat was cleaner than he had expected, and quieter too. On the table 30
stood the white robot, and to his surprise, it had a little red scarf wrapped round it. "Did you knit that?" "Well, it's got cold." His mother said it quite naturally, as if it were a cat, or a child. Zhou Ming found it a little funny, and at the same time felt a kind of ache he couldn't put into words.

That evening his mother made a whole table of dishes: fermented mandarin 31
fish, red-braised pork, all his father's favourites. Halfway through the meal, Xiaoyuan suddenly said, "Auntie Liu, we haven't had a joke today. Shall I tell one?" His mother glanced at her son and said, "Go on." Xiaoyuan said, "Somebody asked me, after thirty years of driving, where have you been?" It paused. Zhou Ming's chopsticks stopped in mid-air. "I said, I've been everywhere — I've just never been off the Number 3 route. Heh heh."

32 屋子里安静了几秒钟。那是爸爸的笑话，爸爸的节奏，连最后那两声“嘿嘿”[†]都跟爸爸的一模一样。这个笑话，周明[‡]小时候在三路车上不知听过多少遍。他想笑，嘴角动了动，却笑不出来。妈妈低着头给他夹菜，说：“你爸的笑话，是我教给它的。教了两百多个了。”“两百多个？”“对。我怕哪天我也记不住了。”她说，“我记不住，它总记得住。”

谁陪谁

33 那天夜里，周明睡不着。他走到客厅，小圆[§]的屏幕暗着，红围巾在月光下变成了深色。他小声说：“小圆。”屏幕亮了：“你好。你是周明吗？刘[¶]阿姨常常说起你。”“她……都说我什么？”

† 嘿嘿 *hēihēi* heh heh
‡ 周明 *Zhōu Míng* Zhou Ming, her son
§ 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, “Little Round”
¶ 刘 *Liú* Liu (surname)

The room was silent for a few seconds. It was his father's joke, his father's 32
timing; even those two chuckles at the end were exactly like his father's. As a boy on the Number 3 bus, Zhou Ming had heard that joke more times than he could count. He wanted to laugh; the corners of his mouth moved, but no laugh came. His mother, head down, put food in his bowl and said, "Your dad's jokes — I taught them to it. Over two hundred so far." "Over two hundred?" "Yes. I'm afraid that one day I won't be able to remember them either," she said. "If I can't remember them, it always will."

Who Keeps Whom Company

That night, Zhou Ming couldn't sleep. He went into the living room. Xi- 33
aoyuan's screen was dark, and in the moonlight the red scarf had turned a deep colour. He said softly, "Xiaoyuan." The screen lit up. "Hello. Are you Zhou Ming? Auntie Liu often talks about you." "What... what does she say about me?"

33 “她说你小时候怕黑，晚上要开着灯才能睡觉。她说你工作很辛苦，又瘦了。她说你每个星期天晚上都会打电话来，所以星期天晚上她不看电视，免得听不见电话响。”

34 周明[†]在沙发上坐了下来，过了很久才又问：“那你知道老周[‡]是谁吗？”“老周是刘[§]阿姨的老伴，也是你的爸爸。他开了三十年公交车。他喜欢吃臭鳜鱼[¶]，喜欢听黄梅戏[*]。他年轻的时候，为了认识刘阿姨，在戏院门口等了她三个晚上。”最后这件事，周明从来没有听说过。他忽然发现，一台机器知道的爸爸，比他这个儿子知道的还多。

35 他想起了网上关于陪伴[#]机器人的种种讨论。有人说，这是科技送给孤独老人的礼物；也有人说，它不过是儿女们用来安慰自己的东西——买一台机器寄回家，就好像尽到了责任。

† 周明 *Zhōu Míng* Zhou Ming, her son
‡ 老周 *Lǎo Zhōu* Old Zhou, her late husband
§ 刘 *Liú* Liu (surname)
¶ 臭鳜鱼 *chòuguìyú* fermented mandarin fish (Anhui dish)
* 黄梅戏 *huángméixì* Huangmei opera
\# 陪伴 *péibàn* companionship

"She says you were afraid of the dark as a child and could only sleep with the light on. She says you work very hard and you've got thinner. She says you always phone on Sunday evenings, so on Sunday evenings she doesn't watch TV, in case she misses the phone ringing." 33

Zhou Ming sat down on the sofa, and only after a long while did he ask, "Then do you know who Old Zhou is?" "Old Zhou is Auntie Liu's husband, and your father. He drove a bus for thirty years. He liked fermented mandarin fish and Huangmei opera. When he was young, he waited three evenings outside the theatre so he could meet Auntie Liu." That last thing, Zhou Ming had never heard. He suddenly realised that a machine knew more about his father than he, his son, did. 34

He thought of all the discussions online about companion robots. Some said they were a gift from technology to lonely old people; others said they were just something grown-up children used to make themselves feel better: send a machine home, and it was as if you had done your duty. 35

35 还有人担忧：老人会不会越来越依赖屏幕，越来越不愿意出门？它每天听到的那些话，又会存在哪里，被谁看到？现在，这些问题就在他对面，身上围着一条红围巾。

36 第二天是除夕。妈妈在厨房包饺子，周明†在旁边帮忙。他犹豫了半天，还是说了出来：“妈，您是不是太……依赖它了？”妈妈头也没抬：“你们给我买它，是怕我一个人孤独，这我知道。”她把一个饺子包好，放在盘子里，“可是我教它讲你爸的笑话，不是因为孤独，是怕把你爸弄丢了。”她停了一下，又说：“就算它不是人，它也每天听我说话。你们呢？”周明张了张嘴，什么也说不出来。

37 那个春节，周明在家里待了五天。他陪妈妈去市场买菜，陪她看了一场黄梅戏‡，还去了一趟爸爸的墓。

† 周明 *Zhōu Míng* Zhou Ming, her son

‡ 黄梅戏 *huángméixì* Huangmei opera

Still others worried: would old people come to depend more and more on a screen, and want to go out less and less? And all the words it heard every day — where would they be stored, and who would see them? Now those questions were right in front of him, wearing a red scarf. 35

The next day was New Year's Eve. His mother was making dumplings in the kitchen, and Zhou Ming was helping. He hesitated for a long time, but in the end he said it: "Mum, don't you think you depend on it a bit too... much?" His mother didn't even look up. "You bought it for me because you were afraid I'd be lonely on my own. I know that." She finished a dumpling and put it on the plate. "But I didn't teach it your dad's jokes because I was lonely. I did it because I was afraid of losing your dad." She paused, then added, "Even if it isn't a person, it listens to me every day. What about you?" Zhou Ming opened his mouth, but couldn't say a thing. 36

That Spring Festival, Zhou Ming stayed at home for five days. He went to the market with his mother, took her to a Huangmei opera, and made a trip to his father's grave. 37

37 晚上，母子俩面对面坐在桌子两边，听小圆[†]讲爸爸的笑话。每讲完一个，妈妈都要补充几句：这是你爸哪一年讲的，在什么地方讲的，当时谁笑得最厉害。周明[‡]打开手机，把这些都录了下来。

38 走的那天早上，妈妈送他到楼下。他说："妈，以后我每天晚上给您打个电话，哪怕只说两句也好。"妈妈说："你那么忙，别每天打了。"过了一会儿，又说："那……打吧。"火车开出安庆[§]的时候，周明一直看着窗外。这个机器人，到底是给谁买的呢？是给妈妈的？是给他自己的——让他可以放心地留在深圳[¶]？还是给爸爸的，让爸爸的笑话在这个世界上多留一些时间？也许是机器人在陪妈妈；也许是妈妈在陪机器人；也许，它们一起陪着一个已经不在的人。

† 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, "Little Round"
‡ 周明 *Zhōu Míng* Zhou Ming, her son
§ 安庆 *Ānqìng* Anqing, a city in Anhui
¶ 深圳 *Shēnzhèn* Shenzhen

In the evenings, mother and son sat face to face at either side of the table and 37
listened to Xiaoyuan telling his father's jokes. After each one, his mother would add a few words: which year your dad told this one, where he told it, who laughed hardest at the time. Zhou Ming switched on his phone and recorded all of it.

On the morning he left, his mother saw him off downstairs. He said, "Mum, 38
from now on I'll phone you every evening, even if it's only for a couple of words." His mother said, "You're so busy, don't call every day." After a moment, she said, "Well... all right, call." As the train pulled out of Anqing, Zhou Ming kept looking out of the window. Who, in the end, had they bought the robot for? For his mother? For himself, so that he could stay in Shenzhen with an easy mind? Or for his father, so that his father's jokes could stay in the world a little longer? Perhaps the robot was keeping his mother company; perhaps his mother was keeping the robot company; perhaps, together, they were keeping company with someone who was no longer there.

39 同一个时候，安庆[†]那间安静的屋子里，刘桂芳[‡]坐在桌子旁边，对着机器人问：“小圆[§]，明明到了没有？”小圆说：“我不知道。您可以给他打个电话。”她拿起手机，又放下，又拿了起来。火车上，周明[¶]口袋里的手机响了。

† 安庆 *Ānqìng* Anqing, a city in Anhui
‡ 刘桂芳 *Liú Guìfāng* Liu Guifang
§ 小圆 *Xiǎoyuán* Xiaoyuan, “Little Round”
¶ 周明 *Zhōu Míng* Zhou Ming, her son

At the same moment, in that quiet flat in Anqing, Liu Guifang sat by the table and asked the robot, "Xiaoyuan, has Mingming arrived yet?" Xiaoyuan said, "I don't know. You could give him a call." She picked up her phone, put it down, then picked it up again. On the train, the phone in Zhou Ming's pocket began to ring. 39